

App watch

Beauty is not just skin deep. Here are some of the best designed and most functional apps across all platforms

Web watch

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Cheaper, by the dozen

Call rates reducing, and a host of affordable smartphones coming your way



Idea launches new smartphones

Idea cellular has launched two new 3G Android smartphones – Idea Ultra+ and Idea FAB – for ₹8,300 and ₹4,999 respectively.

The Idea Ultra+ is a dual-SIM smartphone powered by a 1.3GHz quad-core processor along with 1GB of RAM. The smartphone runs Android 4.2 Jelly Bean. It has a 5-inch display with Gorilla Glass and features an 8MP camera with auto focus and a VGA front facing camera.

The smartphone has 4GB ROM, expandable up to 32GB via microSD. In terms of connectivity, the Ultra+ supports 2G, 3G, Bluetooth 4.0 and USB 2.0. The smartphone is powered by a 2000mAh battery.

The Idea Ultra+ will compete against the likes of Micromax Unite 2 and Moto E.

The Idea FAB is an entry-level Android smartphone featuring a 4-inch display. It runs Android 4.2 Jelly Bean operating system and is powered by

a 1.2 GHz dual-core processor. It also supports dual-SIM, Wi-Fi hotspot and GPS connectivity. Other features of the smartphone include 4GB internal storage and 32GB expandable storage and 3.2MP rear camera with flash.

Like all other Idea 3G smartphones, the new devices also come with a special offer for Idea 3G users offering 3G data benefits of 1.6 GB 3G data and Free Idea TV for 3 months, with a pack priced at ₹259 for existing subscribers, and 1.6 GB 3G data and Free Idea TV for 3 months, with a pack priced at ₹261 for new subscribers.

Idea has consistently focussed on budget smartphones bundled with its data and voice benefits. The telco recently launched the Ultra II and Idea 1000 3G Android smartphones.

Voice-charging your smartphone?

Scientists from Queen Mary University of London (QMUL) and Nokia have created an energy harvesting prototype that can be used to charge your smartphone using everyday noise, like music, traffic or even your voice.

The team of researchers used Zinc oxide to create a voltage by converting energy from motion into electrical energy, in the form of nanorods. Scientists were able to harvest energy and generate a high voltage using the Nanorods. They can respond to vibration and movement created by everyday sound, like music

or voices. Electrical contacts on both sides of the rods can then be used to harvest the voltage to charge a phone.

The scientists started by spraying a coating of liquid zinc oxide onto a plastic sheet, that they placed in a “mixture of chemicals” and heated to 90°C (194°F), which caused the zinc oxide to grow into an array of nanorods. The nanorod sheet was then placed between two electrical contact sheets. The researchers developed a cost-cutting technique that allowed them to use ordinary aluminium foil instead of Gold.

The prototype energy-harvesting device is about the size of a Nokia Lumia 925, and can generate up to five volts using “everyday background noise” such as traffic, music and voices, which is sufficient to charge a mobile phone.

Dr Joe Briscoe from QMUL's School of Engineering and Materials Science said: “Being able to keep mobile devices working for longer, or do away with batteries completely by tapping into the stray energy that is all around us is an exciting concept. This collaboration was an excellent opportunity to develop alternative device designs using cheap and scalable methods. We hope that we have brought this technology closer to viability.”

The Auxus Note 5.5 launched

iberry has launched two new devices - Auxus Note 5.5 smartphone and Auxus AX04i tablet – in India for ₹13,990 and